Q+A

WORLDLY WISE

A retrospective at the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art celebrates six decades of the creative life of eminent artist **Gulammohammed Sheikh**



Q. How did you come up with the title 'Of Worlds Within Worlds' for the retrospective?

I was living in a small town in Gujarat and a world opened for me when I joined the Faculty of Fine Arts in Baroda in 1955. I went to England in 1963 and a third world opened to me. I saw all the great works of art. Then I travelled within India. This wanderlust has been with me from the beginning. 'Of Worlds Within Worlds' seemed apt for this journey.

Q. Why do maps interest you?

I was always interested in maps, but I did not find the kind of map I could work upon. In 2001 or 2002, I discovered a little booklet about maps in a British museum bookshop and found a circular map called the Ebstorf Mappa Mundi (a medieval European map of the world). It was a Christian map and I emptied it of those connotations and kept on adding and changing a few things.

Q. Why do you continue experimenting with mediums, forms and technology?

I like to explore new mediums. I like to keep my vision onto things which I am involved in at that particular moment of time. And it continues. I keep on exploring.

Q. Your works address many contemporary issues around the world. As an artist, how do you not lose hope?

We have lost hope in most things. The world is burning in front of you, whether it is Rwanda or Ukraine or Gaza—there is so much going on and a common human being can't do anything about it. However, I believe that painting or art is equivalent to hope. It tells the story of life and will continue to do so.

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

–with Deepali Dhingra